

burden of inheritance. In spite of the mandate in 2004, she was not the Gandhi who could hold India in thrall. On Saturday, when the last vote in General Elections 2009 was counted and the Congress touched the 200-mark, Sonia Gandhi, the maximum leader of India's Grand Old Party, finally earned the title of Mrs G. Sonia has at last become India's new Indira.

It began with a resounding "no" five years ago when she stood in the Central Hall of Parliament, exuding the glow of an unexpected victory. That day, when India was all set for acquiring its first foreign-born prime minister, she, in a moment saturated with maudlin kitsch, broke the heart of her party by a sensational statement of renunciation. She chose the least ambitious—and the least political—of them all for the top job: the dutiful Dr Manmohan Singh. In the new-born duality of power, she was the undisputed Madonna and he was the most eligible mandarin. Today, as she hovers over her party, the halo has become brighter and Congressmen may find it almost blinding. It also magnifies two other leaders: Manmohan and Rahul Gandhi. This victory underscores the power of three.

For the first time in the narrative of dynastic power, the Gandhi supremacy has been re-established by marketing a commoner. She has restored one of the world's longest surviving political dynasties by being generously democratic. The erstwhile accidental prime minister was a best-selling slogan in the campaign, and perhaps the only slogan the Family found worth selling. In the past, nothing else mattered except the mystique of a Gandhi. In their joint post-victory appearance at 10 Janpath, it was a show of mutual appreciation. While she saluted the people of India for making the right choice, the prime minister attributed the victory to the leadership of Sonia and the "hard work by the youth leader Rahul Gandhi". His humility was an acknowledgement of the truth. The Congress has regained its original identity as an umbrella party under the leadership of Sonia. It is once again the sheltering banyan tree under which everyone could find a place—the Brahmin or the Muslim or the Dalit. She has got the traditional vote bank back. With nearly 30 per cent of the vote share, the party that owes its revival to the new Mrs G resembles the vintage Congress.

The third force in this victory is what will inevitably be the future. Rahul, once the reluctant crown prince, turned the Congress campaign into his own towards the end. Defying the conventional wisdom of the party he was ordained to inherit, Force Rahul set the terms of engagement as allies turned out to be an ever shifting lot. And most audaciously, he opted for a solo act in Uttar Pradesh, the state

that was once the Congress's home. The Rahul doctrine has worked; the party has succeeded in regaining the space it had lost to the BSP and SP to a great extent. The Congress has more than doubled its tally in the state, and the credit goes entirely to him. He says the mandate is a challenge and the real work has just begun. "We will give you a new Congress party in UP," he has said, echoing what his father had said after the massive victory in 1984. This election officially marks the rite of succession in the Congress. And Rahul has flagged off himself from the *karmabhoomi* of the Gandhis.

Set against the triumph of the Congress triad is the tragedy of Lal Krishna Advani, the long distance *yatri* of Indian politics. He has not reached anywhere near the destination, and the party he built has suffered yet another devastating humiliation. By leading a well-oiled presidential style campaign, the 82-year-old Advani had turned the campaign into a referendum on the late-in-life moderniser himself. More than a BJP campaign, it was an Advani march to nowhere. When the "determined leader for a decisive

government" challenged the "weakest prime minister", Sonia made Manmohan a fitting rejoinder to the BJP's prime ministerial fantasy. Advani, the man in permanent makeover, failed to convince India. He didn't have a message that captured the spirit of the times. The BJP, still steeped in identity crisis and ideological confusion, lost the middle class. It miserably missed the presence of a reconciler like Atal Bihari Vajpayee. The challenge ahead for the party is to regain its status as

the party with a difference. And it requires a leadership with a difference to achieve that.

The challenge is equally big for the winner too. The Congress has won by practicing the politics of inclusion, and the mandate is for stability. Still, managing the victory will be the harder task. The new Manmohan government, in spite of the Congress' sensational tally, needs allies, and allies like DMK and Trinamool Congress are ruthless bargainers. They won't settle for lesser portfolios and their national obligations will be subordinated to their regional interests. With the likely inclusion of Rahul in the Cabinet, Delhi is all set to witness the era of triangular power. India has voted for a national party at the worst of times: the Great Recession and a greater threat to the security of the nation. Manmohan may have got the vote for his performance, but he has to perform better to become worthy of the mandate. With his irredeemably shrunken Soviet, the fossilised commissar of AKG Bhavan is not there to haunt him also. The dutiful Doctor has to make the vote for stability an agenda for governance. He cannot afford to disappoint a nation with high expectations. Maybe, showing magnanimity in victory, he should make that slogan of the defeated a reality: "determined leader, decisive government". ■

FOR THE FIRST TIME IN THE NARRATIVE OF DYNASTIC POWER, THE GANDHI SUPREMACY HAS BEEN RE-ESTABLISHED BY MARKETING A COMMONER.